

Prosperity Is by Grace Not by Works

The Deceitfulness of Riches Is Exposed by the Word

Open up to Mark 4, at the end of the thirteenth verse, and we are going to pass in review briefly and take her one step further.

How many of you had a time last night? I guess you can tell I got beside myself. Glory to God, I had a good time.

We have been studying the deceitfulness of riches, which is one of the cloaks Satan hides behind to remove the Word of God out of His saints. We have been studying the devil's tactics and the forces he uses to remove the Word of God out of us.

I do not think there is any other chapter that outlines the basic principles better than Mark 4. That is where we began.

This has been the subject of our teaching, from verses 13 and 14:

| The sower soweth the word.

That is the subject. The objective is how to guard against these five things: persecutions, afflictions, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things. It is how to guard against those five forces and produce up to a hundredfold based on the Word of God.

Go on down again to the eighteenth verse:

| And these are they which are sown among thorns;
such as hear the word.

We have already studied the cares of this world, and now we are majoring on the deceitfulness of riches.

I have meditated the entire Word of God, explored it with everything in me, listened to the Holy Ghost, and finally found the greatest warning Jesus ever gave on the deceitfulness of riches in Luke 16 and Luke 17, which we covered last night.

The Rich Man's Warning Shows Money's Power to Control a Heart

When Jesus gave this strict warning, the teaching He used was the rich man and Lazarus. The rich man ended up in hell because he violated the Abrahamic covenant. He offended because he would not even give Lazarus the crumbs from his table.

Because of that, he ended up in hell. The rich man began to beg Father Abraham to let Lazarus dip his finger in water and put it on his tongue.

When he could get no relief, he switched his begging:

"Father Abraham, let Lazarus rise from the dead and go to my father's house, because I have five brothers. They are living in exactly the same gross violation of the Abrahamic covenant that I did, and I do not want my five brothers to come here."

Father Abraham said, "They have the Word of God. They have Moses and the prophets. Let them hear what the Word says."

The rich man in hell said, "No, Father Abraham. They will not listen to the Word. They never have. But if you will let Lazarus rise from the dead, they will repent."

Father Abraham said, "No, they will not. If they will not believe what the Word of God says, they would not repent if I was dead a week and came back and said, 'Straighten your act up.'"

Jesus was unveiling the power that is in money. It has such power to control a man that even if someone came back from the dead and said, "Straighten your act up. You have been deceived," he said if you will not let the Word of God change your heart, neither will you be persuaded if a man rises from the dead.

Then Jesus continued in Luke 17 and said it is impossible that offenses will not come. Over the impossibility of a man rising from the dead and telling you to straighten your act up, if you will not believe what the Word says, money has such power in it that men will go on offending.

No wonder He taught us on the deceitfulness of riches.

Faith Increases When It Serves the Kingdom Instead of Self

When Jesus told Peter, "If your brother offends you and asks forgiveness over money, you have to forgive him up to 490 times a day," Peter cried out, "My God, Man, You had better increase my faith."

Jesus said, "Peter, if you had faith as a grain of mustard seed, you could say to the sycamine tree, 'Be plucked up by the roots and planted in the sea,' and it would obey you. But which of you is filling the role of a servant and using your faith to serve the kingdom of God?"

That is how the increase comes.

What in the world do you want the money for?

When Peter cried, "Increase my faith," Jesus said in effect, "Sure, Peter. What do you want the increase for? Which of you, having a servant plowing or feeding cattle, would tell the servant when he comes in, 'Wait on yourself, then wait on me'? No. You would tell the servant, 'Wait on me, then wait on yourself.' Then you would not thank him, because he was doing what a top-notch servant is supposed to do: wait on his master first."

That same servant has access to the master's table.

He said, "Peter, you want an increase of faith. What do you want it for? Which of you is filling the role of a servant and using that faith to serve the kingdom of God?"

Do you want it to serve you and your kingdom here?

"Well, just to meet my everyday necessities."

Jesus said you do not even have to worry about that. You do not even have to give that thought. If you are giving it thought, it is because you are already involved and sick in the wrong kingdom. You have no faith. You have been taken over by circumstances.

If the cares of this life did not do it, and you remained in the same condition and suddenly entered into wealth, then the deceitfulness of riches would nail you because you still never changed inside.

He does not care if you have money. What He cares about is whether it has you.

Who is your master? Who is your motivator? Why do you do things?

He said:

So likewise ye,
when ye shall have done all those things which are commanded you,
say,
We are unprofitable servants:
we have done that which was our duty to do.

We are not serving God for gain or profit. We are simply doing what He called us to do. In the proportion that I serve the kingdom of God, that is the proportion He makes the power in money a servant to me.

Riches Become Deceitful Because They Can Finance Other Lusts

What is wrong with us? How do we get deceived so easily?

Notice the deceitfulness of riches is near the end of the list. It is second highest. There is only one thing beyond it: the lusts of other things.

The reason many people get deceived by riches is that they want riches so they can have the lusts of other things. Money can buy lust. It can afford your habits.

When you talk about the lusts of other things, you are talking about things that replace God and destroy you. You are talking about forces of the flesh that can take a man over until he cries for help, yet they still bring his downfall.

Money is second to the top of the reasons men fall because it can finance the other.

Let us get into this riches thing a little more. I want to know what rights I have by the Spirit of God, and I want to know what rights I do not have. I want to know whether I am in a program of works, or whether these things are by grace and, come hell or high water, I could not earn them anyway.

If so, that means it is by faith.

Which one are you working in? It would behoove you to know these things. It is lack of information that causes you to be deceived so easily.

Macedonia's Giving Was Called Grace, Not Religious Bargaining

To begin this, go to 2 Corinthians 8:1:

Moreover, brethren,
we do you to wit of the grace of God
bestowed on the churches of Macedonia;
How that in a great trial of affliction
the abundance of their joy
and their deep poverty
abounded unto the riches of their liberality.

Whatever happened to the church in Macedonia, God called it an act of grace. He said, "I want to call your attention to the grace that was bestowed on the church of Macedonia."

They were in a deep trial of poverty, and they came out of it. The force He listed that caused them to come out of it was their liberality.

Whatever happened to the Macedonian church, He called it an act of grace.

That makes me want to know more.

Hop down to verse 6:

Insomuch that we desired Titus,
that as he had begun,
so he would also finish in you the same grace also.

Look at verse 7:

Therefore, as ye abound in every thing,
in faith,
and utterance,
and knowledge,
and in all diligence,
and in your love to us,
see that ye abound in this grace also.

That is three times in seven verses. If that is not enough, go to verse 9:

For ye know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ,
that, though he was rich,
yet for your sakes he became poor,
that ye through his poverty might be rich.

Do you really know the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ?

He asks, "Do you know this grace?" It is the fourth time in nine verses He mentioned it.

Perhaps we should start by analyzing grace. What is it? If He asks me whether I know it, then I want to know what I am supposed to know.

Grace, in its most basic meaning, is the unmerited, unearnable favor of God bestowed on you and me. Any time you get to thinking you are meriting it, any time you get to thinking you are earning it, you take it out of grace and put it into a program of works.

Righteousness Taught Him That Grace Cannot Be Earned

I first understood grace in righteousness. That was easy for me to understand.

I was in ultra-holiness, and they told me I was a worm, a dog, a low, filthy bunch of rags crawling my way to heaven. They also told me I was a sinner saved by grace.

I said, "What is the difference between me and Joe Sinner on the street?"

They said, "Not a thing. You are just saved by grace."

I believed it. Who do you trust? They were my elders. But something was screaming on the inside of me, "What is the matter with you?"

Brother, when somebody gave me that old box of Kenneth Hagin reel-to-reel tapes, he came on there saying, "What were you born, a man or a woman?"

I said, "A man."

He said, "How did you become a man?"

I was born a man.

He said, "That is how you became righteous. You were born righteous. When you were birthed from the last Adam, Jesus Christ, you were born righteous."

After listening to hours of tapes and praying in the Holy Ghost, He finally made me understand it. I said, "Oh my God, it is not by works, lest any man should boast. It is nothing I can do. It is faith in what He did, not what I did."

Faith in the blood of Jesus Christ made me righteous in what I could not earn and did not deserve. I was locked out of heaven with no access to God. Now I have access to God, not because of what I did, but because of what Jesus did.

That is righteousness, not by my works, lest any man should boast.

I was lost and undone and heading for hell as fast as I could go until Messiah stepped into my shoes, and I recognized that He took every damnable thing I had coming. Now I am free, not by my works, but free.

Then all of a sudden He turns around in 2 Corinthians 8:9 and asks, "Do you understand this grace?"

Christ Bore Poverty as Grace, So Giving Cannot Purchase the Standing

The unmerited, unearnable favor of Jesus was bestowed on you. In substitution, as your spotless Lamb, He was penalized to the maximum with your poverty. He took your penalty. He took your punishment. Then He turned around and gave you a standing you did not deserve and could not earn.

I do not care if you put a million dollars a night in the offering. You could not earn the standing He bestowed on you by an act of grace. It is unearnable.

Otherwise, how could you say to that mountain, "Be removed and cast into the sea," without first checking your bank account to see how much you gave?

Not by your works.

That is what grace is about. If it was earnable, you could have done it. But it is not. You cannot earn it.

This is most of your problem. You have been deceived by riches because you think when you flip your checkbook out and throw a check in the offering, you are somehow earning a standing that was bestowed on you by grace. You cannot do it.

That is why faith is involved. Legal rights. Faith.

You cannot earn that standing. You cheapen redemption every time you try.

"But the Bible says, 'Give, and it shall be given unto you, good measure, pressed down, shaken together, and running over.' I made sure I would get a hundredfold."

Where is it?

"I have been a faithful tither all my life."

I know. Most of you cannot tell much difference between you and the sinner who has given nothing.

I was in that trap. I used to give. Those evangelists were so good I got fined if I left my money at home. Then I would pledge. It did not do any good; they got it anyway.

I used to give desperately, trying to earn a standing He said was bestowed on me by grace. I would give and give, trying to earn that standing, and I would keep giving, saying, "When is it going to come?"

Revelation Turned His Giving From Fear Into Faith

When I found out that praying in tongues edifies me, which simply means it anoints me to understand, I can still remember the day in my prayer closet after hours and hours when the revelation dawned on me.

I jumped up and grabbed Earl Hitz, my old deacon. I said, "My God, I have a new car."

He said, "What? I will agree with that."

I said, "Never mind. I mean, I really have it."

He said, "What?"

I said, "I really have it."

My pathetic works died at the foot of the cross. It is not that I did not labor anymore. I labored more abundantly than ever before, but my faith was not based anymore on my giving, law, or fear. My faith was based on the grace-fact that He bore my poverty.

There is only one way to approach Him, and that is by faith in my God.

The standing I was so pathetically trying to earn gave way. The standing He declared me to have dawned in my spirit when the revelation hit me that I could not give to earn a standing He already said I had.

How could He make me any richer than He already said I was when He bestowed His riches on me in a transference act of grace, substitution, and identification, when He became what I was and I became what He was?

That is why this thing is by faith and not by your works.

He said, "Do you know the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ?"

Bargaining With God Revealed a Works Mentality in Financial Crisis

I had moved to Oregon when the economy crashed. It crashed double there. Unemployment went up to 22 and 23 percent when I was pastoring.

The building industry could not get loans to sell homes, the bottom fell out, and brokers were going broke. Since Oregon supplied about half the lumber, it hit with a double wallop. Construction came to an end, the mills began to shut down, and that was our lifeline.

I found myself counseling one businessman after another, seemingly faithful men of God. Every time I counseled one of them, something would go off on the inside of me. I would try to listen, but I could not quite get what God was trying to get over to me.

I still remember the day it happened. This man's business had just gone broke, and he was trying to start another one. Invariably, these men all said about the same thing. When they saw everything bellying up, they came running in desperation.

"Well, I have always been faithful."

They started giving me the rundown of their works. That was number one.

Number two, they always wanted to bargain.

This particular man said, "Brother Roberson, I am starting a new business because my other one went broke. If you will agree with me and pray, I vow I will give God 30 percent of everything that comes through my business."

For a long time, I had agreed with men like that. But on this particular man, God stopped me. I finally got what He was trying to say.

The Lord said, "You tell that man that I have already done all I can do about his finances."

I said, "You mean he is going to fail?"

He said, "No. You tell that man I have already done all I can do about his finances. I was penalized with them. I bore them, and I turned around and gave him My standing. I have already done all I can do about his finances."

I said, "But he wants to make a deal. He will give You 30 percent."

The Lord said, "No, he will not."

See, he was trying to coax God into moving by promising God what he would do. God said, "I have already done everything I am going to do."

"But I will give 30 percent."

The Lord said, "No, he will not. If he gives 30 percent, he will do it now."

Faith without actions that correspond is dead.

You are not going to make a deal with God because He already made the first step. He is waiting for you to make the second.

"But I want Him to make the first."

He already did.

Seeking His Righteousness Means Finding God's Right Standing in Redemption

What did He say?

Seek ye first the kingdom of God,
and his righteousness;
and all these things shall be added unto you.

What is He talking about? Seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness.

Let me see the hands of everyone here who is the righteousness of God in Christ.

Then if you are, what are you seeking?

You said, "I am righteous." If that is the case, how can you seek something you already are?

His righteousness is different than your righteousness. Righteousness breaks down to mean right standing. In every matter concerning redemption, you need to seek His right standing in it.

He knows you are righteous. He knows you are blood-bought children. That is why He said the man who hears His Word and builds his house on the rock, and the rock is doing His sayings, will stand when the storm hits, the stream rises, and beats vehemently upon the house.

That man dug deep into the revelation knowledge of His Word. He found his right standing and built his house on a rock so solid that hell or high water, there is nothing the devil can do about it.

When He said, "Seek the kingdom of God and His right standing," He meant the standing He proclaimed, the standing He delivered you into when He delivered you from poverty and made you righteous, when He delivered you from sicknesses and pains, when He bore them, when the chastisement of your peace was upon Him and with His stripes you were healed.

He said, "Seek My standing in the kingdom."

When you do, when you free your mind from petty unbelief, then in this operation of faith you free Him unto you. Concerning this realm, He said to seek His standing in it.

The First New Car Became a Love Gift From the Father

I know by the grace of God that He bore my poverty. I probably know that as well as anybody.

I will never forget my first car.

One week before I got it, a multimillionaire was hanging on my shoulder asking, "Is there anything you need?"

I had just gotten ahold of a confession teaching that said I would never again say I had need, sickness, pain, or lack, but would only confess the Word. One of those things was that I would never confess need, but would confess the answer.

This millionaire was hanging on my arm saying, "Is there anything you need?"

My shoes had holes in them. My pants were bright red. My preaching sport coat was bright plaid blue. My shirt was green. It was the only one I had. I was not afraid. My tie was gold simply because it was the only tie I owned.

My old 1958 Chevrolet was parked in front of an old remodeled bowling alley that smelled so bad it would make you sick, and that was where we were having our meetings. That old Chevrolet had cords showing all the way around the tires.

But I had gotten hold of a tape. I was standing on the Word with everything in me.

This millionaire was hanging on my arm saying, "Is there anything you need?"

I could not say it. I said, "No, sir." Then I turned around and walked away. That was the longest walk I ever took.

"Come on, legs. You can do it. Get away."

My wife had gone through two pregnancies in one maternity blouse we got at the Salvation Army. I hurt so badly. Yet I made up my mind: it is His righteousness, His right standing, or nothing.

The Lord ministered to me the next few days in my closet:

"I am the Lord your shepherd. You shall not want. You walk in My Spirit, and you never will."

Two weeks later, I was in a little bitty meeting. When it was over, somebody put a check in the offering for \$5,000. It was exactly the amount of the Volkswagen van on the showroom floor that we had claimed at midnight because all I had was a quarter and did not want any high-pressure salesmen around.

They put the keys in my hand. I was thirty years old. I shook. I wanted the one on the showroom floor so they would have to move all the other ones out of the way.

I got in. My wife got in on the other side. It was fifty miles home. I closed the door, and when I closed it, brother, it was like opium, the smell of the new upholstery. I got high on it. I had smelled it in other people's cars before, sniffing new upholstery.

I was so shaky I could hardly get the key in the ignition. I stuck it in and turned it. My God, it started. It was not like my other one.

I started crying so hard I could hardly get it off the lot. I was bawling like a little baby. I lifted my face toward heaven and wept. The Spirit bathed me in His grace and said, "This is a love gift from your Father."

I wanted to stop every fifteen miles and hug the front of it.

When we got it home, we parked it in front of our house, where it did no good to pull the curtains because you could see us through the walls. It was the worst place in town, but it was all we could afford.

When we pulled up owning every bolt in our brand-new Volkswagen van and parked it in front of that place, it stuck out for three miles. Three months later, we were in another house, ours.

Why?

Roberson found out he could not earn it. He also found out he did not have faith in his God. He found out that when he could not earn it, he did not deserve it. Yet God is more willing than you are to receive.

True Humility Receives Redemption and Becomes a Steward

What did He say would cause these things to be added to you and me?

He said to seek the kingdom of God and His right standing.

Some of you have already had that canceled out of your life by the deceitfulness of riches.

When I tell you one thing, the "believe it and receive it, claim it" bunch that treats prosperity like God's Visa card, I have nothing to do with them.

But the humble bunch who are proud of being poor and doing nothing for God because they do not believe He redeemed them are deceived too. That is false humility.

True humility says that if you will allow the Spirit to work His love in you, then He will give you the heart of a steward, and God will direct your finances while at the same time supplying all your needs.

What did He say?

Seek the kingdom of God first and His righteousness, His right standing in it, and these things will be added unto you.

Owing Nothing but Love Requires Paying What You Owe

Romans 13:8 says:

Owe no man any thing,
but to love one another.

He said to pay tribute to whom tribute is due. Pay your taxes. Pay your bills. Owe no man anything but to love him.

Jesus put me in a perpetual debt of love for as long as I walk the face of this earth. He put me in debt to love you. No matter how many payments I make on that love, He still says, "Roberson, you are in debt."

I can make a thousand payments on that love to you, and He still says I am in debt to that person. I cannot pay it off.

He has charged me to love you, and He has charged you to love me. That is one debt you cannot pay.

He said:

Love one another;
as I have loved you.

That is a supernatural love that extended itself to this world. With no guarantee He would ever reap you, He died for you. Had He not reaped you, He still died for you.

When He says, "Owe no man anything," He means if you owe somebody something, pay it. That is His right standing in the kingdom.

He does not want you bringing reproach on the gospel. Some places I go, they will not rent halls to preachers because the last one did not pay.

That is not right for preachers, and it is not right for you.

If you are going to seek the right standing of God, then you are going to pay your bills. You are not going to have faith until you do.

"I have faith to pay my bills."

Do you? Then pay them.

Augie Learned That Corresponding Action Honors Faith

Augie David, a man from India, came to work for me. He left Portland, Oregon, owing a woman money for a phone bill because he had called his mother and father in India several times. It does not take long calling India to run a bill up.

Then a job opened up with me to live by faith and try to preach, and I was only a year and a half into it myself. So he came with me and left her with the bill, which he intended to pay.

He did not tell me about it. Month after month went by. It was not just a phone bill. There was overdue rent too. He had been with me about six months when I finally got a call from those people.

"This man works for you. Why will he not pay his bills?"

I would have liked to give him some money, but I did not have much to give him. In those days I was learning how to operate consistently myself. I had Pentecostal accidents: some months were good, some were not.

One day I was meditating the Word on seeking the kingdom of God and His right standing, and all this started coming to me.

I said, "Come over here. How much do you owe?"

He quoted the amount. It was several hundred dollars.

I said, "How would you like to just pay that off?"

He said, "Boy, would I like it."

I said, "Did you know faith without works is dead?"

He said, "Yes."

I said, "Are you believing to pay that bill off?"

He said, "Oh yes. I confess it every day."

I said, "How much money do you have over your immediate needs?"

He said, "About ten dollars."

"What are you going to do with it?"

"I am going fishing. I am going bowling."

"With that ten dollars you have? I thought you owed that woman several hundred dollars."

"What is ten dollars going to do?"

If you owe a person one red penny and you have one red penny left over after your necessities, it is not yours. If you want to steal it, that is your business, but it belongs to the other man.

I have never made my family pay. I always gave them their recreation, but I cut mine out. If I owed anybody else, it was not my money to spend.

I said, "So you are going to steal that woman's money?"

He said, "My God, how did you get that?"

I said, "It says here to seek the kingdom of God and His righteousness."

"But I am believing for it."

I said, "No, you are not. Faith without actions that correspond is dead. You want God to pay that bill, but you will not give Him anything to pay it with. If you gave that woman ten dollars toward that bill, you would have honored your own confession, because you would be operating toward what you were saying. That would arm God to give you more seed. What are you going to do, steal it again?"

Seed for the Sower Multiplies When It Is Handled Righteously

Augie started taking his debtors one dollar, two dollars, fifty cents, thirty cents, whatever he had that was not necessary.

His morning services only had six people in them, and my night services had up to seventy-five. He was preaching to those broke-looking people in the mornings. I was training him, though he did not know I did not know much more than he did.

He started doing what I said, and I did not know it. He did that for a few weeks, and his morning offerings came up.

Then a man came in who had sold a house. He sat in all my night meetings with the tithe on that house. Do you think he put it in my offering? No. He put it in Augie's offering.

Augie paid all his bills off with it.

He said, "Thanks for the revelation."

I said, "What revelation?"

"The one that I was stealing it."

I said, "You did that?"

He said, "Yes, I was practicing on you. It works. They are all paid."

I said, "My God, give me the tape."

I started doing it. In one year we paid everything off. Our finances jumped from 150 or 200 a week in those little services by another 500 without anything changing in the amount of people.

What was operating in my heart began to change because I was realizing more grace principles, and I had to put my faith into God's hands through a corresponding action. It was not enough to say, "All my debts are paid."

Correspond if you believe it. Do not steal that man's money and think God can bless a thief.

This was my vendetta. I got my family in trouble, and it was up to me to get them out. I did not take my children's recreation money, my wife's money, or her grocery money. I took the things I would have spent extra on myself.

You want to talk about grace? It is God who gives seed to the sower for his bread and then multiplies the seed sown.

You do not have seed? Are you on the bottom of the barrel? God said He will give seed to the sower. All you have to do is give Him yourself.

Say, "God, here I am. I do not have one red penny for Your kingdom, and I do not have one red penny for my debtors. But You are the God of seed for the sower. I am claiming seed, and I will handle it righteously. I will seek Your kingdom and Your righteousness. You will add this stuff. You will multiply it unto me."

And He will.

Prosperity Serves a Vision Larger Than Daily Necessities

"I am a faith man. My confession is in Him. I said my bills are paid. Come on, Joe, let us go to the show."

Some of you are getting hit pretty heavily. I can tell.

What do you want? Do you want to go on like you are, or do you want out? What do you want me to say?

What did He say? He said, "What do you want prosperity for?"

There is a place in God where you do not have to take thought for your life, what you will eat, or what you will wear. You are capable of producing much more than that.

He said:

Consider the lilies of the field...

Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these.

The God who feeds the sparrow asks, "Are you not worth much more?"

A lily had more than Solomon, and you are worth much more than many lilies. You have access. If you will use that access to meet people's needs as a steward, you have access to more than Solomon had.

But you are not going to get it with no corresponding action. It begins by offering yourself and praying until the kingdom of God is your priority.

What are we locked into anyway?

Our existence for everyday needs should take the least amount of our meditation and thinking. He said you should be at a place where you do not even have to give it any thought. Why? He wanted the operation of your faith to produce much more than that.

How is that for seeking the kingdom?

You are capable of more than Solomon was capable of. You are the righteous seed of Abraham. You have the Holy Ghost. You are capable of more.

But what do you want it for?

You say, "I have the mind of Christ." Not if you are fiddling around with temporary things. Where do you think His vision extends?

If you have the mind of Christ, you are not thinking only of temporary existence on this earth. You are thinking eternal salvation and eternal damnation. I am living in a generation when God converts the power in money to evangelism, and I must do it, come hell or high water. I am going to serve the kingdom.

This temporary existence is as temporary as the vapor of your breath. In the time it takes you to inhale and exhale, your life will be gone. Then you will stand before the Master for the rewards given for the deeds done in this body.

Yet in seeking His right standing, He gave all this to me here as a steward.

If I never appropriate one red penny as a steward for the kingdom of God's sake, it will still be recorded in the annals of heaven that Jesus Christ took Dave Roberson's poverty and gave me His standing, that I might serve the kingdom as that faithful servant.

This is one old boy who will not waste one drop of that drink if I can help it.

Grace Saves the Child, but Fire Tests the Works

Let me calm you down a little.

You may have never put a dime in an offering your entire life. The one person you really love is you. The whole world could go to hell, and it would not bother you much. Everybody around you is miserable because they have to cater to you. Wherever you go, discomfort follows.

Yet you are His child.

You never got out of the crib, but you are His child. For you, my friend, you need to thank God this thing is by grace and not your works.

When you get to heaven, our works will be tried to see what manner they are. He called it a trial as by fire. If there is dross in gold, the fire will burn the dross out just to see how much gold is in the ore. If you do not have any gold in there, everything will burn up. But if you have one little ounce of gold, it will come out.

He will see what the foundation of your works was built on, whether Jesus Christ the chief cornerstone, or hay, wood, and stubble. In other words, He will test whether the deceitfulness of riches was in it.

He will try it by fire to see what manner your works were on this earth. If there is anything left after your trial by fire, you will be rewarded according to what is left, not according to what is burned.

If you end up with nothing, He said you will be saved as by fire. You will have absolutely nothing, but you will be there. You need to thank God it was not your works that got you into heaven.

However, it is what you accomplished by grace that you get rewarded according to.

I do not want to be rewarded like that. When my trial by fire burns everything that was not based on His grace, I want there to be a whole lot left.